Roasted Garlic and Gruyere Mashed Potatoes

Yukon Golds dried in the pot with butter, then loosened with warm cream. Roasted garlic and Gruyere folded in off the heat.

Makes	Active time	Total time
6 cups (serves 4)	About 35 minutes	About 1 hour 25 minutes

Ingredients

Roasted garlic (can be made ahead)

2 heads	garlic, left whole
1 tbsp	olive oil

Potatoes

2 lb	Yukon Gold potatoes, peeled and cut into 1 1/2 inch chunks
1 tbsp	kosher salt, for the cooking water

To finish

5 tbsp	unsalted butter, 2 tbsp for drying and 3 tbsp for the cream
3/4 cup	heavy cream
4 oz	Gruyere, grated on the large holes
1/2 tsp	kosher salt
1/4 tsp	white pepper

Instructions

1. Roast the garlic (50 min). Heat the oven to 400F. Sit the whole heads on a square of foil, drizzle with the olive oil, wrap loosely and roast 45 to 50 minutes, until a head gives when you press it and smells sweet rather than sharp. Cool until you can handle them, then squeeze each head from the root end straight into the mixing bowl. The cloves come out on their own and nothing needs peeling.
2. Boil the potatoes (20 min). Put the potatoes in a large pot, cover with cold water by an inch and add the 1 tbsp of salt. Bring to a boil, then cook 18 to 20 minutes until a knife slides into a chunk with no resistance at all. Start from cold water so the outsides do not blow apart before the middles are done.
3. Drain them properly (2 min). Drain in a colander and leave them a moment to stop dripping. Water left in the potato is butter you cannot add later, so this is not a step to rush.
4. Dry them in the pot (3 min). Put the empty pot back on low heat, add 2 tbsp of the butter and tip the potatoes in. Turn them gently for 2 to 3 minutes until the steam thins out and a faint floury film shows on the bottom of the pot. That film is the sign they are dry and ready to take the cream.
5. Warm the cream (3 min). While the potatoes dry, heat the cream with the remaining 3 tbsp butter until it steams but does not boil. Cold cream cools the potatoes and stiffens the starch, and you end up beating the mash to get it smooth.

6. Mash (5 min). Pass the potatoes through a ricer back into the warm pot, or mash by hand. Do not use a food processor or a stick blender: the blades shear the starch granules open and the mash turns to glue in seconds.
7. Add the cream (3 min). Pour in the warm cream and butter in two or three additions, folding with a spatula rather than beating. Stop while it still holds a soft shape on the spoon.
8. Fold in the garlic and the Gruyere. Take the pot off the heat completely. Fold in the squeezed roasted garlic, which breaks up on its own as it goes through, then the Gruyere a handful at a time until it is melted and the mash is smooth. Residual heat only: above about 160F the cheese tightens, squeezes out its fat and goes stringy.
9. Season and serve. Salt and white pepper. Taste now and not before, because the Gruyere and the cooking water have both already salted it.

Notes

- Yukon Gold mashes buttery and holds its shape. Russets go fluffier and drier and will drink more cream, so add it a little at a time if you use them.
- The garlic keeps three days in the fridge under a film of oil, and roasting the heads while the oven is on for something else is the easiest way to get this on the table in 35 minutes.
- Folding the Gruyere off the heat is not fussiness. Hard alpine cheeses break above roughly 160F, and a broken mash is greasy and stringy with no way back.
- To hold it before serving, cover and set the pot over a pan of barely simmering water, then stir in a splash more warm cream just before it goes out.
- Grate the Gruyere on the large holes. Finely grated cheese clumps as it hits the heat; larger shreds melt into the mash more evenly.